

TermiChat

User Guide

A terminal chat application for local networks.

1. Introduction

TermiChat is a chat application that runs entirely inside your terminal. Instead of a browser or a desktop window, you get a keyboard-driven interface with a message pane, a live list of who is online, and a command prompt at the bottom.

It comes in two parts: a server, which one person on the network runs and which holds the accounts, the chat rooms and the messages, and a client, which each participant runs on their own machine to connect to that server and chat.

Everything is done with typed commands, all of which start with a slash — for example `/join general` to enter a room. Anything you type that does not start with a slash is sent as a message to the room you are currently in.

2. Getting Started

You need Node.js installed. The server must be running before anyone can log in.

Start the server

One person on the network does this, in a terminal:

```
cd server
npm install
npm start
```

The first command moves into the server folder, the second installs what the server needs (only required the first time), and the third starts it. The server listens on port 4000 by default and stays running — leave this terminal open.

On its very first run the server creates four ready-to-use accounts and four rooms (`#general`, `#random`, `#dev` and `#help`), so you can start chatting immediately.

Start the client

Each participant does this, in their own terminal:

```
cd client
npm install
npm start
```

The login screen appears as soon as the client starts.

Note: your terminal window should be reasonably large. The screenshots in this guide were taken at roughly 129×34 characters, which gives the interface room to lay out properly.

3. Logging In

The login screen is a single bordered box titled TermiChat login, with three fields stacked vertically and a reminder of the keys at the bottom.

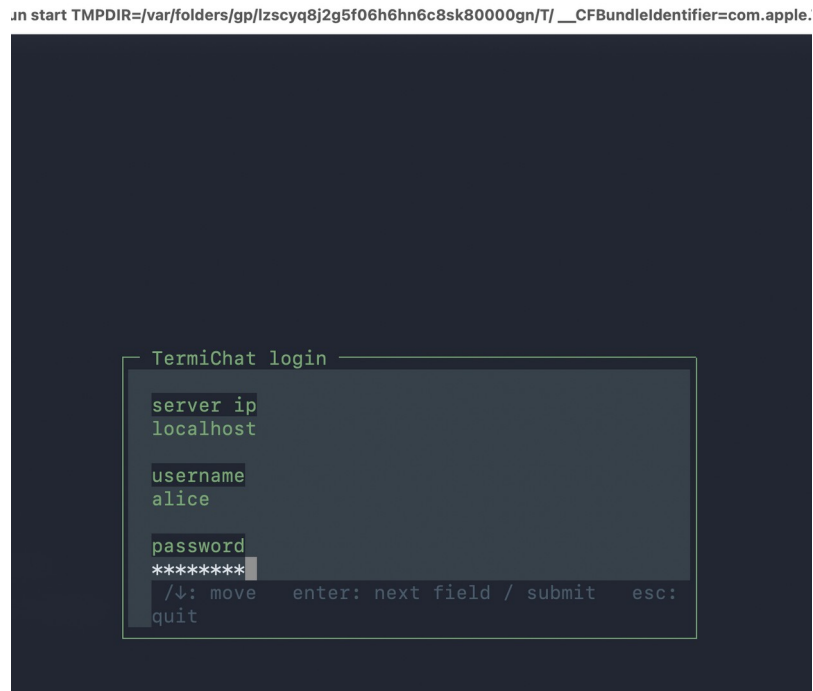


Figure 1 — The login screen. The password is masked as you type, and the footer line recalls the navigation keys.

Field	What to enter
server ip	The address of the machine running the server. Use localhost if the server is running on your own computer, or its network address (for example 192.168.1.4) otherwise.
username	Your account name.
password	Your password. It is hidden as you type and displayed as asterisks.

Moving around the form

- **↑ and ↓** move between the three fields in either direction. Whatever you have already typed is kept.
- **Enter** moves to the next field. Pressing **Enter** on the password field submits the login.
- **Esc** closes the client without logging in.

If a field is left empty, or the username and password do not match, a message is shown in the box and you are returned to the password field to try again. The same happens if the server cannot be reached — check the IP address and that the server is actually running.

Default accounts

The server creates these four accounts on its first run. They exist so that the application is usable and testable straight away — they should be changed before using TermiChat for anything real.

Username	Password
admin	admin123
alice	alice123
bob	bob123
carol	carol123

The same account cannot be logged in twice at the same time. If you want two windows chatting to each other, use two different accounts.

4. The Chat Screen

Once you are logged in, the login box is replaced by the main chat screen. It is divided into four areas.



Figure 2 — The chat screen just after logging in as bob. No room has been joined yet, so the title bar and the prompt both read "no room" and the sidebar is empty.

Title bar

The strip along the top shows the application name, the room you are currently in and how many people are in it — for example `termichat — general — 3 users`. Before you join anything it reads `termichat — no room — 0 users`. On the right-hand side is a permanent `/help` reminder.

Message pane

The large area on the left is where the conversation appears. Three kinds of line show up here:

- Chat messages, with the time and the sender's name, e.g. `[21:10] <carol> hello world`
- Notices from the application, shown in yellow and starting with an arrow, e.g. `→ Welcome to TermiChat, bob!` or `→ bob joined general`
- Errors, shown in red and starting with a cross, e.g. `x User "alice" not found` or `x Unknown command: /hello`

When you join a room, its recent history is replayed so you can see what was said before you arrived. The pane scrolls as new lines come in.

ONLINE sidebar

The bordered box at the top right lists the people in the room you are currently in, each with a dot beside their name. It updates by itself the moment somebody joins, leaves, disconnects or changes their name — you never need to refresh it. Before you have joined a room, or when you are alone in one, it reads (no one else here).

Room information panel

Just below the sidebar, three values are shown:

Line	Meaning
room	The room you are currently in, or "no room" before your first <code>/join</code> .

Line	Meaning
users	How many people are in that room.
uptime	How long you have been logged in, counting up every second in HH:MM:SS.

Input prompt

The single line at the very bottom is where you type. It shows the room you are in between square brackets, for example [general] \$, or [no room] \$ before you have joined anything. Press Enter to send.

Type ordinary text to send a message to your room; type a line starting with a slash to run a command. Pressing Ctrl-C at any time closes the client.

5. Commands

Every command is typed at the input prompt and confirmed with Enter. Words in angle brackets are values you replace.

Command	What it does
/join <room>	Enter a room, leaving your current one. If the room does not exist yet it is created for you.
/msg <user> <text>	Send a private message to one person. Only you and they will see it.
/who	List everyone currently logged in to the server, in all rooms.
/rooms	List all rooms that exist on the server, so you know what you can join.
/nick <name>	Change the name others see next to your messages.
/clear	Empty your own message pane. Nothing is deleted for anybody else.
/help	Show the list of available commands in the message pane.
/quit	Log out and close the client.

The rest of this section shows each command in use.

/help — list the commands

Type /help and press Enter. The full list of commands is printed as a yellow notice line in the message pane.

```
client — TermiChat — node • npm run dev TMPDIR=/var/folders/gp/izscyq8j2g5f06h6hn6c8sk80000gn/T/___CFBundleIdentifier=com.apple.Terminal XPC_FLAGS=0x0 — 129x34

termichat — no room — 0 users /help

→ secure channel established

type /help to list available commands

→ connected to 192.168.1.4:4000 as bob
→ Welcome to TermiChat, bob!
→ /join <room> /msg <user> <text> /who /rooms /nick <name> /clear /help /quit

room: no room
users: 0 online
uptime: 00:01:12

/help
```

Figure 3 — /help prints every available command on one line.

/who — see everyone online

This lists all the people logged in to the server, whichever room they happen to be in. Here the reply is online (all rooms): cozycoder, carol, bob — note that the sidebar is still empty, because bob has not joined a room yet.

```
client — TermiChat — node • npm run dev TMPDIR=/var/folders/gp/izscyq8j2g5f06h6hn6c8sk80000gn/T/___CFBundleIdentifier=com.apple.Terminal XPC_FLAGS=0x0 — 129x34

termichat — no room — 0 users /help

→ secure channel established

type /help to list available commands

→ connected to 192.168.1.4:4000 as bob
→ Welcome to TermiChat, bob!
→ /join <room> /msg <user> <text> /who /rooms /nick <name> /clear /help /quit
→ online (all rooms): cozycoder, carol, bob

room: no room
users: 0 online
uptime: 00:02:15

/who
```

Figure 4 — /who lists everyone connected to the server, not just the people in your room.

/rooms — see the available rooms

This lists every room that exists on the server. Alongside the four rooms created at startup, you can see general — a room somebody created simply by joining a name that did not exist yet.

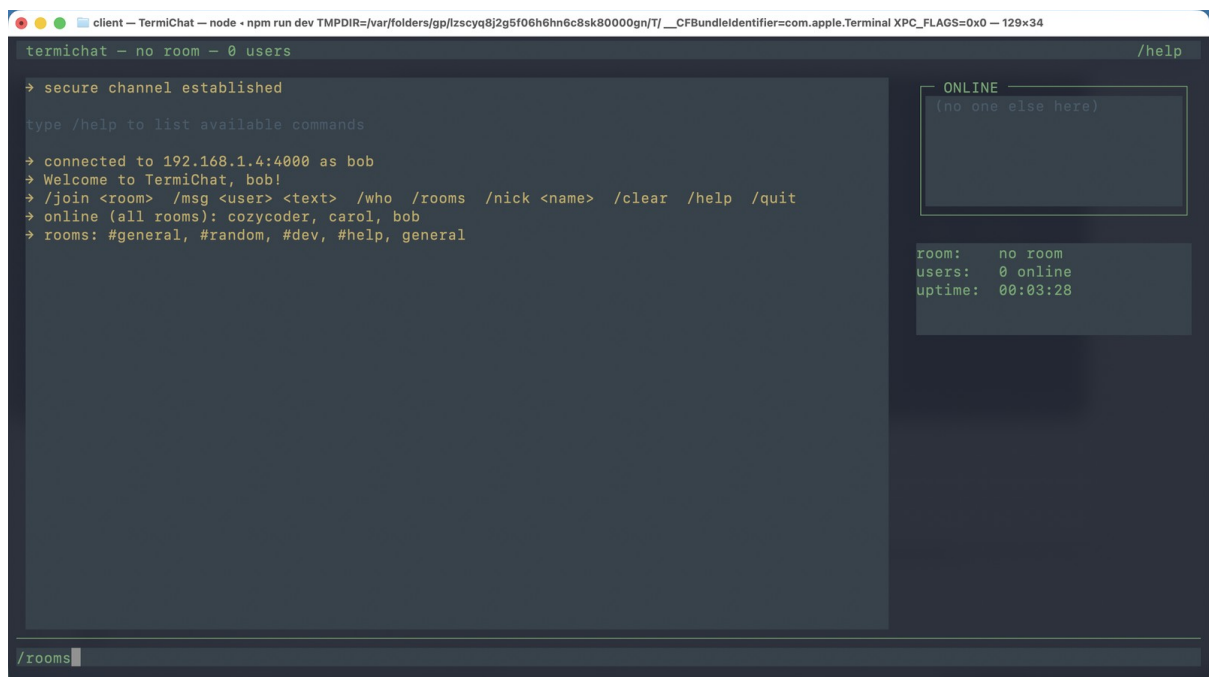


Figure 5 — /rooms lists all existing rooms, including ones created on demand.

/join — enter a room

Type /join followed by the room name.

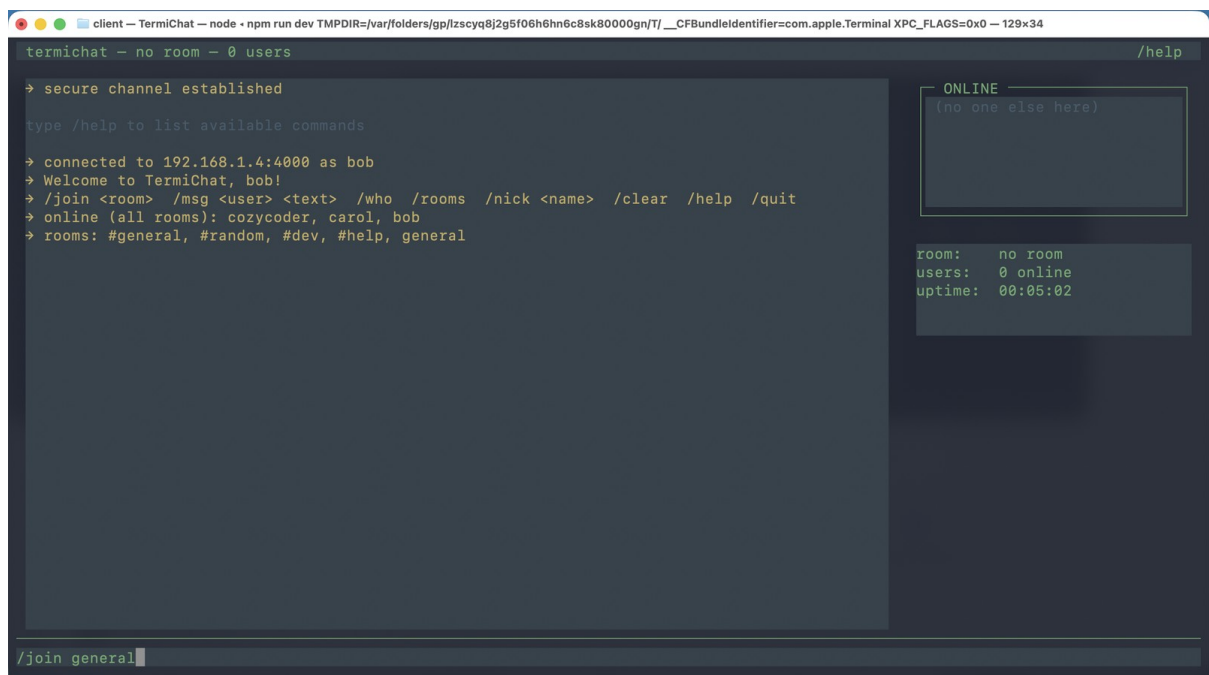


Figure 6 — Typing /join general at the prompt, before pressing Enter.

As soon as you press Enter, three things change at once: the title bar and the room panel show the new room, the sidebar fills with the people who are in it, the prompt becomes [general] \$, and the room's recent history is replayed so you can see what was said before you arrived.

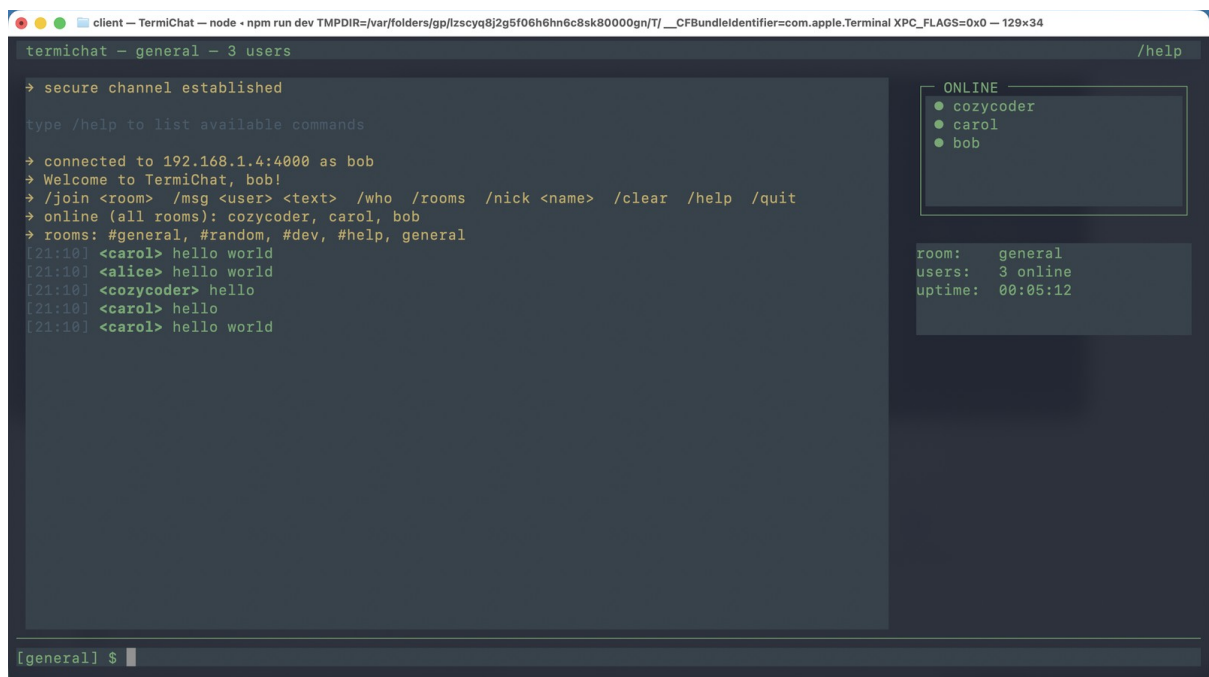


Figure 7 — After joining: title bar, sidebar, room panel and prompt all reflect the room, and past messages are shown.

Sending a message

Once you are in a room, you do not need a command — just type your text and press Enter.

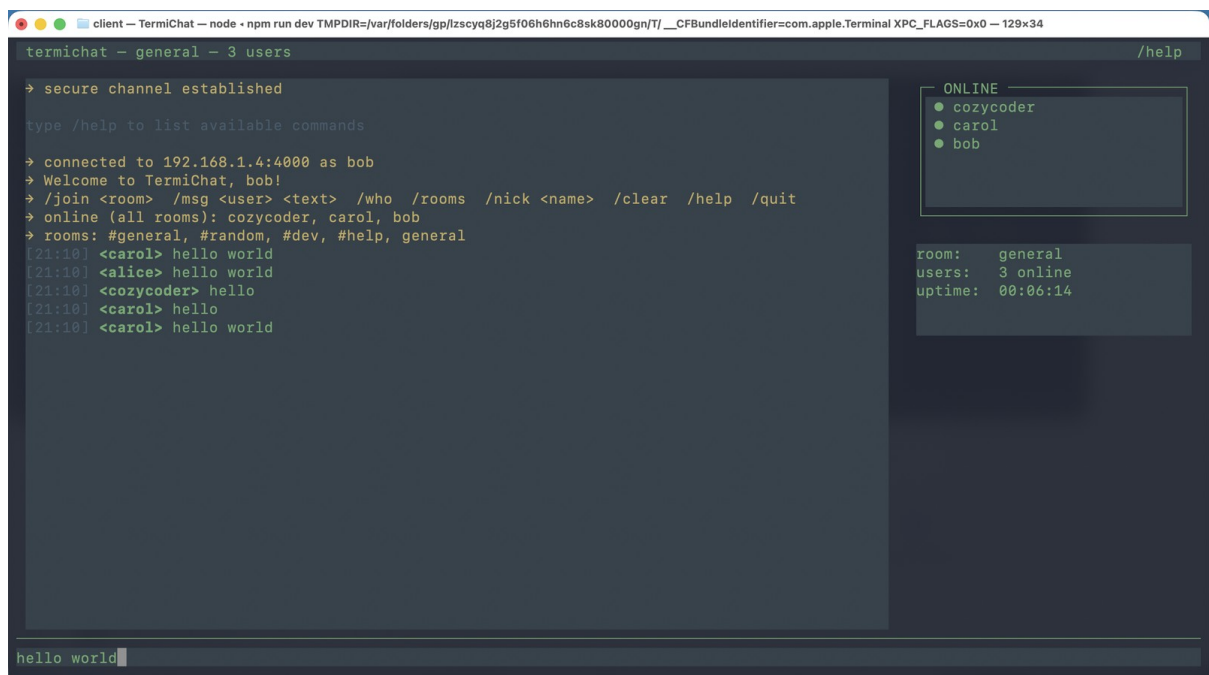


Figure 8 — Typing an ordinary message. Anything that does not start with a slash is sent to the room.

Your message appears in the pane with the time and your name, exactly as everyone else in the room sees it.

```
client — TermiChat — node • npm run dev TMPDIR=/var/folders/gp/izscyq8j2g5f06h6hn6c8sk80000gn/T/___CFBundleIdentifier=com.apple.Terminal XPC_FLAGS=0x0 — 129x34

termichat — general — 3 users /help

→ secure channel established

type /help to list available commands

→ connected to 192.168.1.4:4000 as bob
→ Welcome to TermiChat, bob!
→ /join <room> /msg <user> <text> /who /rooms /nick <name> /clear /help /quit
→ online (all rooms): cozycoder, carol, bob
→ rooms: #general, #random, #dev, #help, general

[21:10] <carol> hello world
[21:10] <alice> hello world
[21:10] <cozycoder> hello
[21:10] <carol> hello
[21:10] <carol> hello world
[21:11] <bob> hello world
[21:11] <bob> test
```

Figure 9 — The two messages sent by bob now appear at the bottom of the conversation.

/msg — send a private message

Type /msg, then the person's name, then your text. Here bob sends a private message to carol.

```
client — TermiChat — node • npm run dev TMPDIR=/var/folders/gp/izscyq8j2g5f06h6hn6c8sk80000gn/T/___CFBundleIdentifier=com.apple.Terminal XPC_FLAGS=0x0 — 129x34

termichat — general — 3 users /help

→ secure channel established

type /help to list available commands

→ connected to 192.168.1.4:4000 as bob
→ Welcome to TermiChat, bob!
→ /join <room> /msg <user> <text> /who /rooms /nick <name> /clear /help /quit
→ online (all rooms): cozycoder, carol, bob
→ rooms: #general, #random, #dev, #help, general

[21:10] <carol> hello world
[21:10] <alice> hello world
[21:10] <cozycoder> hello
[21:10] <carol> hello
[21:10] <carol> hello world
[21:11] <bob> hello world
[21:11] <bob> test
x User "alice" not found
[21:14] <cozycoder> hello

/msg carol hi carol
```

Figure 10 — Typing /msg carol hi carol. The red line above is an earlier attempt to message a name nobody was using.

The message is shown to both people, with an arrow indicating the direction. On carol's screen it arrives as **<pm**
<- bob> hi carol — the arrow points toward her, meaning received.

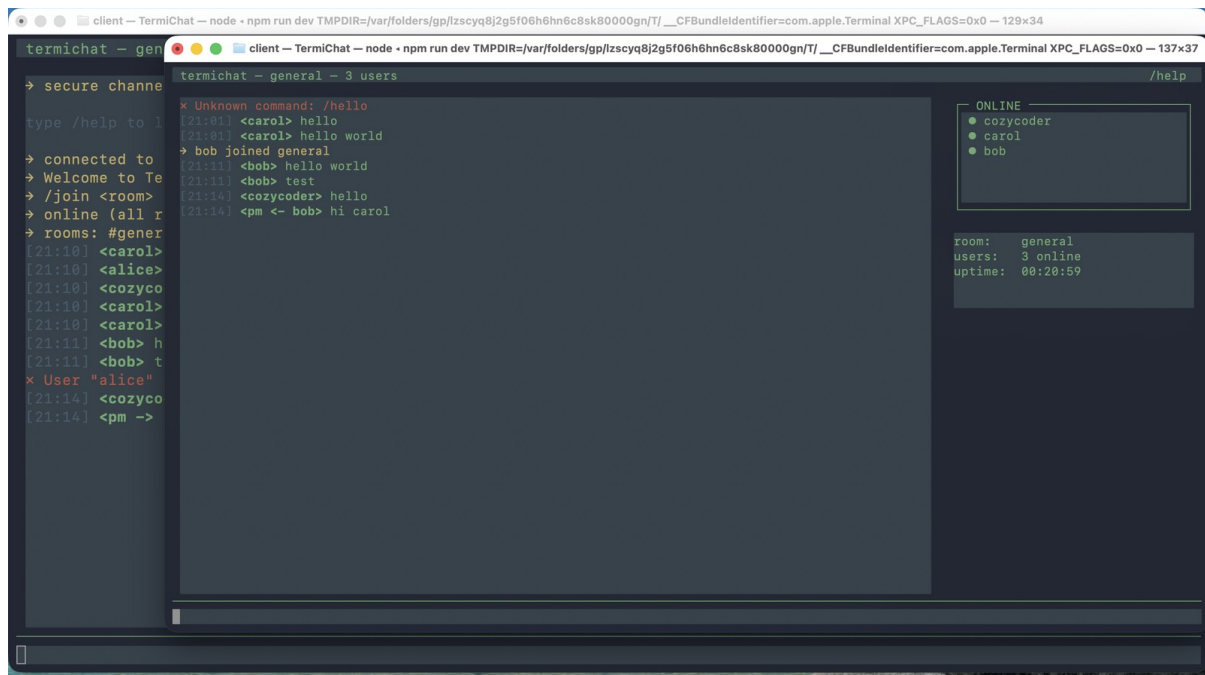


Figure 11 — Carol's window (front) receives the private message from bob.

On bob's own screen the same message reads **<pm -> carol> hi carol** — the arrow points away from him, meaning sent. Nobody else sees it: in the window in front, alice is in the same room at the same moment and her conversation contains no trace of the private message.

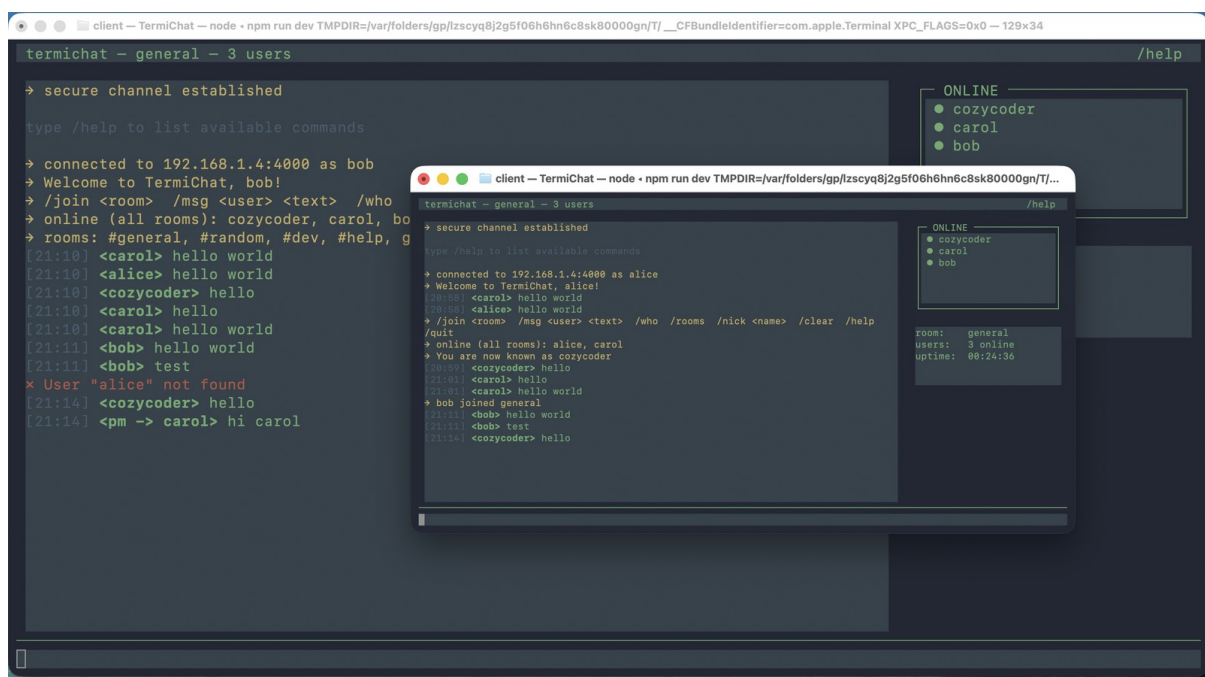


Figure 12 — Alice's window (front) is in the same room but shows nothing — private messages reach only the two people concerned.

If the name does not match anyone who is logged in, you get **x User "... not found**. Names must be spelled exactly as they appear in the sidebar or in **/who**, and a person who has changed their name with **/nick** must be addressed by their new name.

/nick — change your display name

Type **/nick** followed by the name you want to use.

```
client — TermiChat — node • npm run dev TMPDIR=/var/folders/gp/ltzscyq8j2g5f06h6hn6c8sk80000gn/T/___CFBundleIdentifier=com.apple.Terminal XPC_FLAGS=0x0 — 129x34

termichat — general — 3 users /help

→ secure channel established

type /help to list available commands

→ connected to 192.168.1.4:4000 as bob
→ Welcome to TermiChat, bob!
→ /join <room> /msg <user> <text> /who /rooms /nick <name> /clear /help /quit
→ online (all rooms): cozycoder, carol, bob
→ rooms: #general, #random, #dev, #help, general
[21:10] <carol> hello world
[21:10] <alice> hello world
[21:10] <cozycoder> hello
[21:10] <carol> hello
[21:10] <carol> hello world
[21:11] <bob> hello world
[21:11] <bob> test
× User "alice" not found
[21:14] <cozycoder> hello
[21:14] <pm -> carol> hi carol

/nick nwname
```

Figure 13 — Typing /nick nwname at the prompt.

TermiChat confirms with You are now known as ..., your new name is used on every message you send from then on, and everyone's sidebar is updated straight away — bob has become nwname in the ONLINE list.

```
client — TermiChat — node • npm run dev TMPDIR=/var/folders/gp/ltzscyq8j2g5f06h6hn6c8sk80000gn/T/___CFBundleIdentifier=com.apple.Terminal XPC_FLAGS=0x0 — 129x34

termichat — general — 3 users /help

→ secure channel established

type /help to list available commands

→ connected to 192.168.1.4:4000 as bob
→ Welcome to TermiChat, bob!
→ /join <room> /msg <user> <text> /who /rooms /nick <name> /clear /help /quit
→ online (all rooms): cozycoder, carol, bob
→ rooms: #general, #random, #dev, #help, general
[21:10] <carol> hello world
[21:10] <alice> hello world
[21:10] <cozycoder> hello
[21:10] <carol> hello
[21:10] <carol> hello world
[21:11] <bob> hello world
[21:11] <bob> test
× User "alice" not found
[21:14] <cozycoder> hello
[21:14] <pm -> carol> hi carol
→ You are now known as nwname
[21:19] <nwname> hello world
```

Figure 14 — After the rename: the confirmation line, the new name on the next message, and the updated sidebar.

The change lasts for the current session only. Logging in again puts you back to your account name.

/clear — tidy your view

Type /clear to empty the message pane.

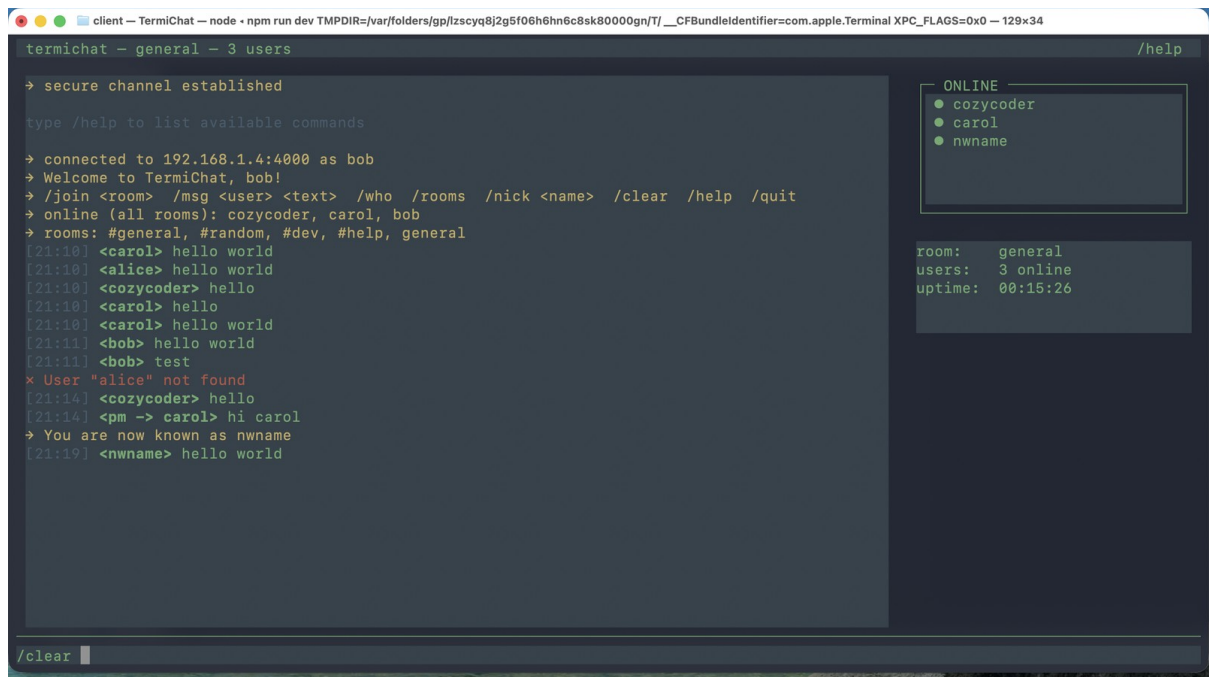


Figure 15 — Typing /clear, with a full conversation on screen.

Only the message pane is emptied. The title bar, the sidebar and the room panel are untouched, and — importantly — nothing is deleted for anyone else.



Figure 16 — Immediately after /clear: the conversation is gone, everything else stays in place.

The conversation carries on as normal: new messages simply start filling the empty pane again.

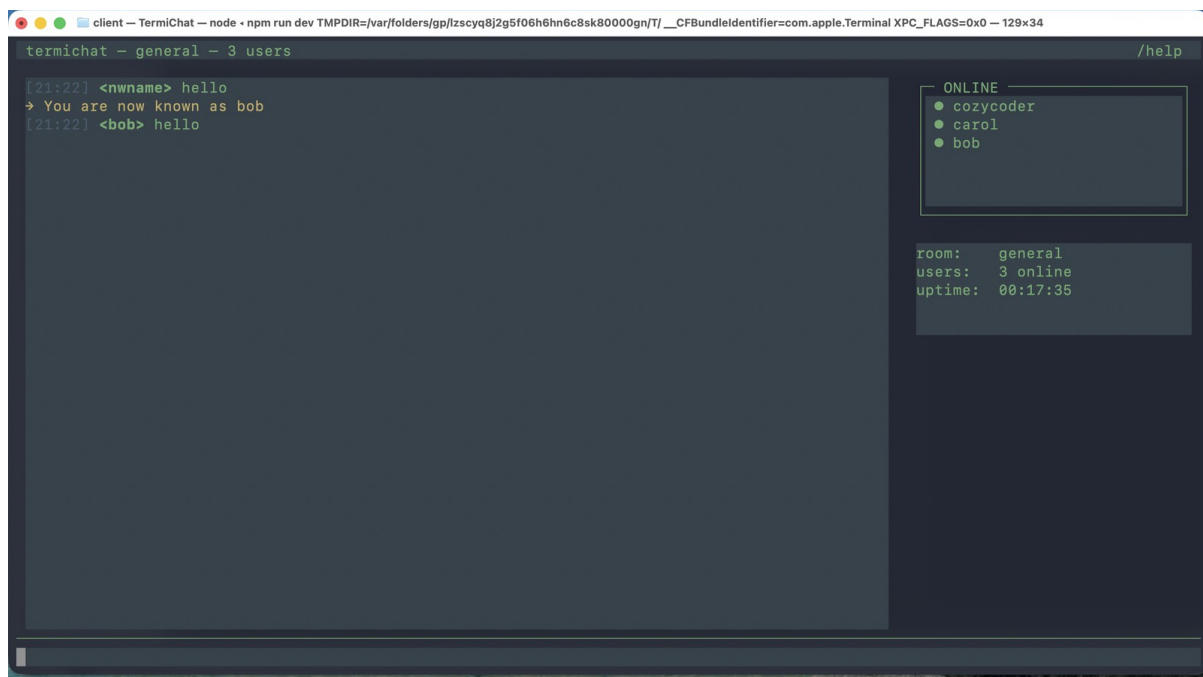


Figure 17 — New activity after clearing — messages and notices resume in the emptied pane.

/quit — leave

Type `/quit` to log out and close the client. Other people in the room see you disappear from their sidebar.



Figure 18 — Typing `/quit` ends the session and returns you to your shell.

6. Tips and Things Worth Knowing

- **The sidebar and `/who` are not the same thing.** The ONLINE sidebar shows only the people in your current room; `/who` lists everyone logged in to the server, whatever room they are in. Someone can be online without appearing in your sidebar.
- **Uptime is your own.** The uptime counter measures how long you have been logged in, not how long the server has been running. Each person sees their own figure.
- **`/clear` only affects you.** It wipes your message pane; the sidebar, the room panel and everyone else's screen are untouched.

- **Joining a room leaves the previous one.** You are only ever in one room at a time, so messages sent to the room you left will not reach you.
- **Rooms are created on demand.** Joining a name that does not exist creates it — which also means a typo silently puts you in an empty room of your own. Check with `/rooms` if you expected company.
- **Nothing is kept permanently.** Rooms and their message history live in the server's memory only. Restarting the server clears every room and all messages.
- **Only one session per account.** If a login is refused, check that the same username is not already connected from another window.
- **Forgot the commands?** Type `/help` — the reminder is also always visible in the top-right corner of the screen.